

to the one in Microsoft Word. The post-OCR text editor is comprehensive, just like in most of the other software we reviewed. The list of output file formats is absolutely huge—you can export your results to just about any application.

'OCR scheduling' lets you schedule OmniPage to OCR a list of documents at a particular time. Another feature is 'Direct OCR' that allows you to recognise pages while working in a word processor or other application. It lets you scan, recognise and paste recognition results directly into your current file at the cursor position, without leaving the application.

OmniPage did falter a bit when presented with less-than-perfect scans such as photocopies. Also, when presented with a magazine page that was laid out in a haphazard way—with text and images close to each other, and reverse fonts and quotes all over the place—OmniPage did manage to recognise all the individual words, but not in quite the same order and spacing as in the original. Coloured text didn't remain coloured either.

But all in all, OmniPage is an excellent piece of software. For the serious user—especially business users—the price tag of \$600 (Rs 28,000) is well justified.

- + Comprehensive tools; high accuracy
- Expensive, imperfect at times

ABBYY FineReader Professional 6.0

Almost perfect

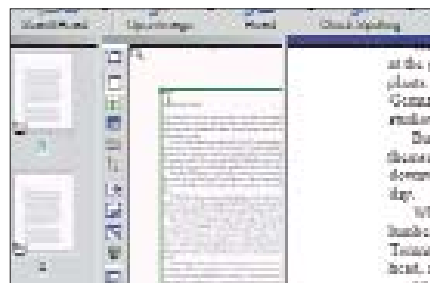


FineReader is one of the best OCR software available. The best thing about FineReader is its sheer versatility—whether it's about file formats, or the kinds of document it can recognise.

When FineReader scanned the newspaper clip in our tests, every bit of the layout and formatting, all the fonts and images—just about everything—was retained. The resulting file looked just like the original newspaper clipping!

How does OCR work?

First, the software segregates the image into paragraphs, lines and characters. Then, the traditional method of visual mapping between the image and the database is done. The latest breed of OCRers use optimisation algorithms, neural networks and some AI concepts. For example, FineReader's Integrity Purposefulness



FineReader has many more features than you would probably use

FineReader has wizards all over the place, so that you can get to work even without knowing how the software works.

The main screen is well-laid out, with four buttons—Open, Read, Spell-check and Save. Each of these has drop-down lists with options, for example, specifying properties of the document, whether to retain formatting, how FineReader will work with the images and many more. The process is not complex though—you can use the default options and let FineReader do everything for you.

Features-wise, FineReader is packed to the brim. You can scan and read multiple images at the click of a button. There are options galore; such as 'Despeckle Image' in case you have a poor-quality document. FineReader ensures that you'll never have scanner problems—a single click sends FineReader searching for your scanner.

The spell-check options rival those available in Microsoft Word. Get pages recognised with FineReader running in the background, so you don't have to sit and look at the screen while doing the OCR. Customising almost everything is a breeze—the way your scanned pages are displayed, the way different panes appear, and so on. There's also a pattern editor that enables you to customise FineReader to suit particular special characters or formats. FineReader boasts a thorough and comprehensive help menu, and online help is provided.

FineReader 7.0 has just been

Adaptability (IPA) technology guesses that a character is an 'H' even if the scanned image doesn't contain a horizontal bar in the character. It is actually based on the recognising pattern humans follow, using which it tries to guess the character as a whole. It then looks at all possibilities and tries to arrive at a hypothesis. The software adapts from what it has learnt.

Indian Languages

One of the important features of any OCR package is the number of languages it supports. Having additional language support translates to practically creating a new OCR engine. Chitrakan is one such OCR tool that supports Hindi and Marathi, apart from English. It has a pretty decent list of tools, and comes for Rs 10,000 for a single license. You can extract images directly from any TWAIN-compliant scanner or camera. The company claims the use of some advanced Digital Signal Processing algorithms for removing the noise and 'Back Page Reflection' to get more accurate results. Chitrakan is a product in the line of software using Graphics and Intelligence-based Script Technology (GIST) to facilitate the use of Indian languages in IT.

There are other products such as iLeap—a word processor, Leap mail—a mail client and LISM—a tool that enables the use of Indian languages on Linux-based applications.

released—it claims to have 25 per cent better accuracy overall, and 45 per cent for PDF conversion. You can export the scanned document to XML and PowerPoint, and also to PDF format—so you don't need the Acrobat writer. FineReader 7.0 supports remote installation, the jpeg2000 format, Intel hyperthreading technology, barcode recognition and full text search, with morphology support. There are new legal and medical dictionaries, which, ABBYY claims, improves recognition of legal and medical documents by 30 to 40 per cent.

Suffice it to say that with FineReader, you've reached the end of the road as far as OCRing is concerned, you simply won't need anything else—if you can afford the \$300 (Rs 13,800) cost.

- + Unparalleled accuracy; well worth the price
- None

Readiris Pro 8

Needs spectacles

The interface is the first thing that would strike anyone new to using Readiris Pro. It consists of two vertical bars that contain the relevant icons. Readiris comes with an OCR wizard that takes you through the text-recognition process. You can take the